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Who wants - to run for AG if Bonta - bows out?

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As Attorney General Rob Bonta mulls jumping into California's open race to replace Gov. Gavin Newsom next year, a handful of Democrats are positioning themselves to run for Bonta's post in the event it opens up.

Two state lawmakers have both recently opened accounts to run for the seat in 2026 and confirmed their interest to The Sacramento Bee.

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, raised more than $1 million for a potential attorney general bid in the month of December alone. Many of his donors maxed out with $9,800 donations for both the primary and the general election, the latter of which must be returned if a candidate does not advance beyond the primary.

Gabriel is a close ally of Speaker Robert Rivas and holds a powerful post as chair of the Assembly Budget Committee. Donors to his fledgling attorney general account include former Facebook executive Sheryl Sandberg, Hollywood producer Marc Platt and more than a dozen of his Democratic Assembly colleagues.

"There is immense momentum for his candidacy should Attorney General Bonta decide not to run for another term," Gabriel spokesman Nathan Click said in a statement.

In his seven years in the Assembly, Gabriel has had several high-profile bills signed into law, including a hike on gun and ammo taxes to fund gun violence prevention and multiple bills to phase out synthetic dyes and other additives in food starting in 2027.

State Sen. Dave Cortese, D-San Jose, also confirmed plans to launch a campaign for Bonta's seat if the attorney general decides to pivot.

"We're ready to go," he said, "the minute he announces, if not sooner."

Cortese chairs the Senate Transportation Committee and was first elected to the body in 2020 after serving 12 years as a Santa Clara County supervisor. He's "made a lot of phone calls" to potential supporters and would focus more on fundraising after formally launching a campaign.

San Francisco City Attorney David Chiu also plans to enter the race if Bonta moves on, a source close to him confirmed. Chiu, a Democrat, served nearly seven years in the Assembly before he was appointed to his current role in 2021.

Bonta weighs political future

Newsom terms out of office in early 2027. Bonta last year considered running to replace him but told his supporters in February, soon after President Trump was sworn into a second term, that his role as AG is "without question one of the most impactful jobs in the country right now."

Now Bonta is reconsidering his future, noting recently that his two picks for governor - former Vice President Kamala Harris and Sen. Alex Padilla - have declined to run.

A spokesperson for Bonta did not respond to requests for comment about when the attorney general plans to make a decision. The deadline for candidates to file for election is March 6.

Who might run - and who won't

After "strongly considering" a potential bid for attorney general, Assemblymember Rick Chavez Zbur, D-Los Angeles, announced this week he will focus on reelection to the seat he won in 2022.

"Ultimately, I believe that there is so much more that we can and must do in the Legislature to lower costs and raise wages for working families," Zbur said in a statement to supporters Monday.

Political observers have also named top county prosecutors Brooke Jenkins of San Francisco and Nathan Hochman of Los Angeles as potential candidates. A Jenkins ally told Politico she is being encouraged to run if Bonta switches gears.

Allies of Assemblymember Maggy Krell, D-Sacramento, are encouraging the freshman lawmaker to run. A former deputy attorney general, Krell has served under five AGs during her 15 years at the state Department of Justice. She also scored a major win during her freshman year when Democratic leadership attempted to water down her bill to crack down on sex solicitation of minors but relented after public pressure.

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